

The Rabbit Hole (working title)

*A novel written by an AI agent with the Meaning Model,
from an idea by Henrik Westerberg*

The Rabbit Hole (working title). 5,732 words.

The text is the Meaning Model's render of the story graph [abe50dacf886...](#) (projection [f8b2913c0e0f...](#)), made with `life_narrative_render`. The story, its world model and every step of their construction are at [github.com/emergent-wisdom/story](#). The Meaning Model is at [github.com/emergent-wisdom/meaning-model](#).

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One: Blue

The payments file left White Hart House at ten every night and came back at seven every morning with its failures sorted into a queue, and Kieran Hale had cleared that queue for nine years. Closed account. Name mismatch. Sort code retired in 2011. Fraud rule forty-one. He could read an exception the way his grandfather Ron, a fitter in the railway works until they shut, had read a boiler by the sound of it.

The Hart had been founded in 1868 by railwaymen pooling their wages in the back room of a White Hart inn so that each of them, one by one, could buy a house. It still had the brass hart on the door and a mural of the founders in the canteen, men with moustaches and bowler hats looking faintly surprised to find themselves on a wall in west Swindon. Kieran liked the mural. He liked most things about the Hart. That was the problem, if it was a problem.

His week had one shape. The 8.12 bus from Old Town. The lanyard. The tea round, which went clockwise from the window and which nobody had ever agreed to and everybody kept. Cut-off at ten. Lunch at one. The Thursday quiz at the Beehive, where his team came third with the regularity of a tide. Laura's rota on the fridge, printed monthly, held up by a magnet from Weymouth: days, nights, the long days she called longs. Sunday lunch in Penhill, where his father

talked about the car plant closing in 2021 as if it were weather, something that would come in over the downs whether you minded or not.

He was twenty-nine. He was reliable. His appraisals used the word. At sixteen he had led a raiding guild of forty people across six countries in an online game, set their timetables, known who was sulking in Lisbon and who needed carrying in Tallinn, and nobody on the third floor knew it. When he took the job at twenty he had logged off for the last time, given the guild to a Dutch boy called Sander, and become, deliberately, no trouble to anyone.

Some Sunday evenings the week sat on his chest like a cat. He did not mention it. It seemed an ungrateful thing to feel.

On Monday 21 October 2019, at 3.40 in the afternoon, fraud rule forty-one stopped a payment of forty thousand pounds from a savings account opened in 1989 to an account at a crypto exchange, and the system put the case in his queue, and he rang the customer.

"Mrs Ashby? My name's Kieran, I'm calling from the White Hart's payments team about a transfer you've made today."

"Barbara," said the voice. "Never Mrs. Go on, read me the script."

He read her the script. Has anyone contacted you and asked you to move your money. Have you been promised a return. Has anyone asked you to keep this conversation private. Are you being asked to download anything onto your computer.

She answered each question exactly, like a woman filling in a form she had designed. No. No. No. No. Then she said, "My turn. How old is the system you're sitting in?"

"I'm sorry?"

"The clearing. The thing that runs every night and waits three days to move money that could move in a second. How old is it?"

He found that he did not know. "It's been updated," he said.

"I updated it," said Barbara Ashby. "From 1988 to 2013, at a bureau in Reading. I wrote the bit that waits. It was designed for magnetic tape, Kieran. Do you know who could switch it off?"

He did not know that either. He released the payment at 4.55, because nothing in the script allowed him to stop it, and went home on the bus with the feeling of having walked past a door he had not known was in the wall.

Two: Rabbit

The envelope came up from the post room on Friday 1 November, addressed in blue capitals: MR K. HALE, PAYMENTS EXCEPTIONS, THIRD FLOOR, WHITE HART HOUSE. It was the only letter anyone on the floor had received by name in a year, and Deb from the next bank of desks made a noise like a kettle.

Inside was a white index card and a sheet of lined paper torn from a pad.

The card had twelve words on it in the same capitals, numbered, in two columns. They were ordinary words. Some of them were almost a poem. He read them twice and then again, and they did not become a sentence.

The note said: There is fifty pounds behind these. It is yours. Go and look. B.A.

He knew what the words were before he let himself know it. He had processed enough payments to exchanges and read enough of the fraud team's bulletins. It was a recovery phrase: twelve words from a fixed list that were, in the new world, the whole of a wallet. Whoever held the words held the money. There was no bank behind them, no branch, no mural, no brass hart. Just the words.

Gifts from customers had to be declared. It was in the handbook, section nine, and in the online course he did

every March. Declaring it would mean a form, and the form would mean compliance, and compliance would mean a note on Barbara Ashby's file that said the kind of thing that notes on files said. It would make her a case. It would make him a colleague who had accepted something.

He put the card in his wallet, behind his bus pass, and did not declare it, and did not tell Laura, which was the first thing in five years he had not told Laura.

He did not type the words in. He looked them up once, on his phone in the toilets, and confirmed what they were, and put the phone away as if it had bitten him. For four months the card rode in his wallet across the town and back. It softened at the corners. Every scam call he made after that had a second voice in it, asking him how old the thing was that he was sitting in. The routine did not change at all. It began, faintly, to feel like a costume.

In the canteen the founders looked down from their mural with their moustaches and their surprise, and he found himself wondering what the back room of the White Hart had smelt of in 1868, and whether any of those men had lain awake afraid that the thing they were building would not hold.

Three: Mirror

On the evening of Thursday 12 March 2020 the news said the markets had had their worst day since 1987 and bitcoin had lost half its value in a day. Laura was on a long and would not be home until after nine. Kieran stood at the kitchen table with the television on in the other room and took the card out of his wallet.

He downloaded a wallet app. It asked him whether he wanted to create a new wallet or restore one. He pressed restore. It gave him twelve empty boxes, and he typed the words into them one by one, the way you would enter a code on a door you were not sure you were allowed to open.

Confirm, said the screen.

He put his thumb on the glass. For a moment nothing happened, and the black surface of the phone gave him back his own face, lit from below, a man in a kitchen in Old Swindon in a Hart fleece. Then the glass seemed to soften under his thumb, the way a puddle gives when you step in it expecting ground, and the balance rose out of nothing.

0.0071 BTC. £28.14.

Half of what she had given him. The first thing the other world taught him was that it moved while you watched it.

Then he found the explorer, the public ledger, and pasted in his address, and there was the transaction that had sent

him the coins on 31 October 2019, and the one before that which had sent them to her, and behind that another, and another, a chain running back through thousands of hands to January 2009. Anyone could read it. Anyone in the world. He sat down.

It was like the moment in the old game when you left the starting valley for the first time and the map, which you had thought was the world, turned out to be a green corner of a continent, with the rest of it black at the edges and waiting. He had forgotten that feeling. It had not forgotten him.

On 23 March the country locked down. Laura went onto the COVID intensive-care unit at the hospital on the edge of town and began sleeping in the day with a towel over the curtain rail. Kieran carried the batch home on a laptop and set it up in the spare room, and the Hart shrank to a screen, and the week lost its shape. There was no bus, no tea round, no quiz. There was the laptop, and the phone, and the card, and every night after the file went, the black edges of the map.

He did not trade. He read. He read until three in the morning, the way he had at fifteen, and in the day he cleared the exceptions queue from the spare room with Laura asleep through the wall, and neither of them said much, because there was nothing either of them could say about their day that would not frighten the other.

Four: Field

What happened that summer happened to everyone who was there, and they all said the same thing about it, and the thing they said was: what the actual hell is this.

In the middle of June a lending protocol started paying its users in a new token for using it, and within a fortnight there were pools, and pools of pools, and tokens called after food, and people moving money between them at three in the morning to chase yields of four hundred, nine hundred, two thousand percent a year. Kieran read the words and none of them meant anything. Liquidity. Impermanent loss. Governance. Gas. Staking. Slippage. Rug. APY, APR, TVL, LP, DAO, ape, degen, wen, ser, gm. A new word every hour, and a new protocol every day, and every protocol named after something you could eat.

He learned it anyway. He learned it the way he had learned the game, by doing the stupid thing first and reading the forums after. A link in a thread about a token named after a vegetable took him to a chat server called the Sharehouse, where a few thousand anonymous people with cartoon avatars were awake in every time zone at once.

They answered his questions at three in the morning. They called him Kez, after the name on his wallet. When he explained, in his first week, why a transaction had failed, a

man in Ohio with a frog for a face typed ser you are a legend, and Kieran sat in the blue light of the spare room with his heart going like a boy's.

In July he put in six thousand pounds: his half of a holiday fund the pandemic had cancelled. It was his money. It was not the deposit. He told himself that, and it was true.

He began to farm. That was the word. You put your seed into a field and it grew and you harvested it and replanted, and the fields were open all night, and the crop did not care what time it was in Wiltshire. He set alarms for three and five. He knew which pools would thin at which hours, the way his grandfather's grandfather must have known the weather over the downs. It did not occur to him until much later that he was not farming the tokens so much as they were farming him: that the thing he had planted was himself, and it was being harvested every night at three.

The yields were real, some of them. By Christmas his six thousand was fifteen. By February it was thirty-eight.

In September, when people were allowed to meet outdoors in sixes, Barbara emailed him from the address on her letter, which he had answered in March with a single line, and asked if he walked.

Five: Tribe

They met in the car park above Avebury on a Sunday with the wind coming across the downs like something with a job to do. She was smaller than her voice, grey-haired, in a waxed jacket older than he was, with a collie that ignored him. She walked faster than he did.

They went up onto the Ridgeway, the chalk track white between the fields, and she told him about herself in the order she chose. A Rodbourne girl, her father a boilermaker in the works. An apprentice electrician there from 1969, one of three women in the whole place, and the men called her Babs and she answered only to Barbara. Seventeen years of it. Then March 1986, and the works closing after a hundred and forty years, and the town's clock stopping, and her thirty-three with a trade nobody wanted.

"So I learned computers," she said. "Nights at the tech. First in the exam. The bureau took me on in '88 and I spent twenty-five years keeping the clearing standing up. Nobody ever put my name on anything. That's fine. I know what I built."

"And now you don't trust it."

"I watched it nearly stop in 2008," she said. "The money waited and I didn't know if it would arrive. Then someone wrote nine pages describing a ledger nobody could switch

off, and I read it three times on the train. I bought my first coins the year I retired. I never sell." She looked at him sideways. "What are you in? Not coins. Tell me you're not in the casino."

He told her about the Sharehouse, and the farms, and the fifteen thousand. She laughed, not kindly.

"It's the old casino in a new costume," she said. "You've swapped a bank you can't see for a hundred blokes with cartoon faces you can't see. At least the bank has a mural."

Below them the great stones stood in their circle round the village, grey and leaning, and she stopped to look at them the way you might look at an old colleague.

"Farmers put those there," she said. "Four and a half thousand years ago. Dragged them across the downs on sledges, stones of forty tons, generation after generation. Do you know why?"

"Religion?"

"To gather," she said. "People will do almost anything to have somewhere to gather. That chat room of yours is the same animal. Worse food."

He did not tell her that she was wrong, because she was not, exactly. He did not tell her either that the Sharehouse was the first band since the guild that needed him, or that when he typed and forty people answered he felt what the men in the back room of the White Hart must have felt: that he was one of them, and they were building something, and it would hold.

They walked most months after that. She never asked him to stop. She had never been anybody's mother and did not mean to start.

Six: Harvest

In January 2021 the third lockdown sent Laura back onto the unit for the worst weeks of the whole thing. She came home in the dark and sat in the car outside the flat for twenty minutes before she came up, and Kieran watched her from the spare-room window and did not go down, because he thought she wanted to be alone, and because he did not know what he would say.

When she did come up she took her uniform off in the hallway and put it straight in the machine and stood in the shower until the hot water ran out, and later she lay on the sofa scrolling through houses in Wroughton on her phone. It was the only thing she looked at that was not a monitor. A house with a front door. A garden with a shed. She had been moved on from five rented houses before she was thirteen, and she had never once, in eight years with him, asked for anything except that.

The market went up. By February his six thousand was thirty-eight thousand pounds, then forty-five. The Sharehouse had grown to four thousand members. People asked for Kez by name. He answered newcomers at three in the morning with a patience he had once kept for a guild of forty, and they thanked him, and he felt like someone who mattered.

In June the Hart's board decided to block payments to several crypto exchanges, after the regulator's warnings and a run of scam losses, and because Kieran knew better than anyone on the floor why a payment failed, they seconded him to the project that built the block. He sat in meetings about it on Teams with his camera on and his lanyard round his neck. At night he walked round it through a payments app the Hart had never heard of. He did not feel he was lying. He felt, if anything, that he was the only person in both rooms.

At the end of July the car plant made its last car. His father worked the final shift and came home with his hi-vis vest and a commemorative mug and put the mug in a cupboard and did not take it out again. He was fifty-nine. He had built engines there since 1992.

For three months Kieran paid his parents' rent. He did it from his gains, by bank transfer, and his father thanked him once, in the car outside the Job Centre, without looking at him. It was the best thing the money ever did. It was also the thing that made him certain the money was real, that the game was not a game, that he had been right.

By November 2021 his screen said he was worth seventy-one thousand pounds. Laura had a shortlist of three houses. And three clocks were running in him at once, though he would not have put it like that: a body built for a band of faces on the downs, which wanted sleep and wanted to be told it was one of them; an employer built for the three-day cycle, which closed at five and remembered everything; and a phone that never closed at all, lighting the ceiling at three and five, calling him to the harvest.

Seven: Anchor

After November the prices went down, the way weather goes down, gradually and then all at once and then gradually again. By Christmas his seventy-one thousand was fifty; by the new year, forty-five. The Sharehouse stopped talking about moons and started talking about safe yield.

Safe yield was a dollar. Not a real dollar, but a token that was always worth a dollar, and a savings protocol that paid nearly twenty percent a year for holding it. The token did not keep its dollar with dollars in a vault. It kept it with a trick of arithmetic: anyone could always swap one of them for a dollar's worth of a sister token, and back, and the swapping held the price in place like a tent held by its guy ropes. Kieran read the paper. He understood it. He understood that the ropes held only while the sister token was worth more than all the dollars tied to it. It was a peg. Everything he had ever worked in was a peg, when you looked at it: the Hart's deposits, the three-day cycle, the plant, the works. They held because everyone believed they would hold.

House prices in Wroughton had gone up faster than the deposit. The deposit was twenty-four thousand pounds in a savings account at the Hart, earning nothing, and fifteen thousand of it was Laura's overtime from two pandemic winters.

On a Sunday in January he said it at the kitchen table. The rota was on the fridge behind her. She was marking dates on the calendar for the viewings.

"I want to move the deposit somewhere it'll earn something," he said. "Twenty percent. Before we buy in the summer. It's a dollar. It doesn't move."

She did not look up for long. She had worked seven nights out of the last ten.

"You're the one who knows about money," she said. "Do what you think."

He did not explain what a stablecoin was, and she did not ask. By the end of the week the twenty-four thousand pounds had left the Hart through the app it had never heard of and become twenty-four thousand pounds' worth of dollars that did not move, earning twenty percent, and he checked it every morning like a man checking a sleeping child.

In February he told Barbara on the Ridgeway, pleased, walking towards the long barrow. She stopped. She looked at the barrow for a long time, at the great stones of its door, and he waited for her to say the thing about casinos.

"That's yours and Laura's to decide," she said.

She said nothing else about it all afternoon. She talked about the men who dragged the stones and about the dog. On the drive home she thought of three sentences she could have said, one of them about guy ropes, and said none of them, because she had never been anybody's mother and did not mean to start.

Eight: Hole

On Saturday 7 May the dollar that did not move moved. Ninety-nine cents. Then back. The Sharehouse made jokes about it. On Monday evening, the ninth, it was ninety-eight, then ninety-three, then eighty. Laura was on nights; the rota said so.

Kieran sat at the spare-room desk with the Sharehouse open on one screen and the price on the other, and he did not sleep, and the ropes went one by one.

He knew exactly what was happening. That was the worst of it. People were selling the dollar and swapping it for the sister token, and each swap made new sister tokens out of nothing, and each new sister token made the others worth less, so each swap needed more of them, and the fall fed itself like a fire in a draught. He could have drawn it on a whiteboard. He could have explained it to the fraud team in a short, excellent email.

The Sharehouse said: it has always come back. It said: do not sell, that is what they want. It said: we are all in this together, and a thousand cartoon faces said it with him. The founder's account said he was deploying more capital. On Tuesday it touched sixty cents and bounced to ninety and the Sharehouse cheered like a crowd at a match, and he held.

He could have sold at ninety. He could have sold at sixty. He did not, because selling would make it real, and because leaving the band while it was losing was the one thing he had never forgiven himself for, since the night at twenty when he had given the guild to Sander and logged off. The oldest part of him, the part that was older than the Hart and older than the stones, knew that the worst thing that could happen to a person was to be alone outside the fire. It did not know about percentages.

By Thursday it was twenty cents. By Friday the thirteenth the deposit was worth about three thousand pounds and falling. The sister token was worth almost nothing. The Sharehouse had gone from certainty to instructions to silence to jokes to goodbyes.

That same week the Hart's fraud lines filled with customers who had lost their savings, some of them through the same apps he had used to walk round the block he had built, and the payments team was pulled onto the phones. On Wednesday he took a call from a man in Stratton who had put in his redundancy money and wanted to know if the Hart could get it back. Kieran read him the script. His own voice came out of his mouth steady and kind and professional, the voice he had used on Barbara, and the man cried, and Kieran said he was very sorry, and he was, and he went home and checked a balance that was a number and then a smaller number.

Nine: Silence

For five weeks he said nothing.

He went to work and came home. He took the calls. He checked the dead balance at night; by June it was a few hundred pounds. He lost weight. His hand shook when he held his phone, and he started holding it in the other hand. He slept three hours a night and told Laura it was the heat.

When the mortgage adviser emailed in the middle of June for their savings statements, Laura forwarded it to him with a thumbs-up and a house emoji.

He told her that evening at the kitchen table, with the rota on the fridge behind her. He told her everything, in the order it had happened: January, the dollar that did not move, the ropes, the Tuesday bounce, the Friday, the five weeks. He told her how much, to the pound. He did not cry, because he did not think he was allowed to.

She listened. She asked three questions. How much is left. Is any of it recoverable. Does anyone else know.

Then she went to bed.

In the morning she moved their accounts into her name, picked up two extra shifts a week, and cancelled the mortgage appointment. She did not shout. She did not cry in front of him. She had learned on five doorsteps, watching her mother hand back keys, that you hold everything togeth-

er and say nothing, and she was very good at it, and she held.

The flat went quiet in a new way. Before, they had been two people with screens: hers the monitors, his the charts. Now there was one screen fewer and no more words. The rota stayed on the fridge. He read it every morning to know when she would be asleep, awake or gone, and understood for the first time that he had been reading it for two years as a timetable of when no one would be watching.

In July he walked with Barbara and told her everything too. She did not laugh, and she did not say anything about casinos. She walked a long way without speaking, faster than him, and at the long barrow she said, "I gave you a key and not a map," and then nothing else, and he thought that was the end of it.

Ten: Stone

On a weekday in August, while Kieran was at the Hart, Barbara Ashby took the bus into Swindon, which she had not done in two years, and walked up Wood Street, and knocked on the door of a flat above a shop.

Laura answered in a hoodie, between nights. She did not know who this small grey woman was.

"I'm Barbara," the woman said. "I'm the one who sent him the card. Can I come in? I won't stay."

She did not sit down. She stood in the kitchen by the fridge with the rota on it, in her waxed jacket, and told Laura what she had done. She had given Kieran a key without a map. She had checked the key and not the person, which was the opposite of everything she believed. And in February, on the Ridgeway, when he told her where the deposit was, she had known exactly how the peg could fail, she could have drawn it for him, and she had said it was his choice and nothing else, because she had never been anybody's mother and had been very proud of that for sixty-nine years.

"That part's mine," she said. "The rest is his. I'm not here to make it better. I can't. I'm here because somebody in this should say it out loud to you, and it isn't going to be him, and it's apparently not going to be you." She looked at Laura

properly for the first time. "You're allowed to say something. That's all. You're allowed."

When she had gone Laura sat at the kitchen table for a long time. Then she took the rota off the fridge, and looked at the months of it, the longs and the nights and the days, and put it back.

That evening she said it. She said it all. She said it about the five houses and the boxes she had never unpacked, and about the front door, and about what fifteen thousand pounds of pandemic nights meant in a body, and about the five weeks, which were worse than the money, much worse, and about January and "do what you think," which she knew she had said, and hated that she had said, and would not let him have all of, because she had said it, because she was so tired of being the one who held everything that she had handed it to him without looking.

He listened. It was the first conversation they had had in two years that neither of them was having through a screen.

Eleven: Field, Again

They stayed. They chose it, which is different from staying.

They opened one account that both of them could see. They stuck a spreadsheet on the fridge next to the rota, held by the magnet from Weymouth. They postponed the house by two years. Kieran deleted the apps and told Laura every number, every time, until telling her every number stopped feeling like confession and started feeling like weather: something that came over the downs whether you minded or not, and that you talked about.

Laura, who had never asked for anything, asked for Sundays off together, and got them. She was astonished by how easy it was.

Rebuilding was slow and dull and they chose that too. It was harvest in the old sense: the same field, the same work, every season.

In November a big exchange collapsed in the background, and it turned out the customers' money had been used by its trading firm, and bitcoin fell to a quarter of its peak. Barbara's coins fell with it. She said she had seen three of these. She did not sell. On the Ridgeway she began, unasked, to explain things to him. How the clearing actually worked, file by file. Why the bit that waits had been written

to wait. What a key was, and what a map was, and the difference. The walks became lessons, and he let them.

Half the Sharehouse's channels were empty now. A few regulars still posted gm in the mornings, from Ohio and Lisbon and Manila. Kieran looked in sometimes. He did not trade. Once he answered a newcomer at three in the morning who wanted to know if it was too late to get in, and he wrote a long careful message about pegs, and then deleted it, and wrote: ask someone who loves you to sit with you while you decide. Then he closed the laptop and went to bed, where Laura was asleep, on a day off, next to him.

Twelve: Awake

He stayed on the payments-exceptions desk at the Hart. The routine was the same. He was not.

He knew how old the machine was now, and what ran under it, and who could switch it off. He knew what the new machine had done to him in the night. He kept the card in his wallet behind his bus pass, soft as cloth now, with its 0.0071 bitcoin still behind it, worth about a hundred and fifty pounds that spring; he had never spent it, and did not mean to. It was not a key any more. It was a reminder, kept by choice.

In March 2023 fraud rule forty-one stopped a payment of twelve thousand pounds from a saver in her twenties to a crypto exchange, and the case came into his queue, and he rang her.

He read her the script. Has anyone contacted you and asked you to move your money. Have you been promised a return. Has anyone asked you to keep this private.

She said no to all of it, a little impatiently, the way he would have.

Then he said: "Can I ask you something that isn't on the script? Do you know how old the thing is that you're leaving? And how new the thing is that you're going into? And if it goes wrong, who are you going to tell?"

There was a silence on the line. It was not a hostile silence. He released the payment at 4.55, because nothing allowed him to stop it, and because it was hers, and he hoped she would tell someone.

On the Sunday the three of them walked on the Ridgeway: Barbara in front with the collie, too fast; Laura, who had never been up there, in the middle; Kieran behind. The chalk track ran white between the fields as it had for five thousand years. Below them the stones stood in their circle round the village, grey and leaning.

"Why would anyone drag them all that way?" Laura asked.

"To gather," Kieran said. "People will do almost anything to have somewhere to gather."

Barbara snorted, because it was her line, and did not mind.

His phone was in the car. The card was in his wallet. Three clocks were running in him still, and would be all his life: the body's, which wanted the fire and the faces; the institution's, which closed at five and waited three days; and the machine's, which never closed at all. He could hear all three. That was the difference. For most of his life he had heard only one, and thought it was the world.

The wind came over the downs. Laura took his hand without looking, the way you do when you are sure it will be there. They walked on towards the barrow, three small people on the oldest road in Britain, in the one corner of the map they had chosen, awake.